

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

A *tithi devo bhava* or “guest is god” may be the credo for the tourism ministry, but the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) fears that demons may enter the country in the garb of guests. It thinks it's safer to keep a few genuine visitors out than to allow a David Coleman Headley to have a free run in the country looking for targets to bomb. In addition to strengthening the intelligence network, the MHA is working out ways to ensure that no one succeeds in breaching the visa barrier like 26/11 Mumbai terror accused Headley and Tahawwur Hussain Rana, a Pakistani-Canadian businessman based in Chicago. Both had multiple entry tourist visas issued by the Indian consulate in Chicago. They travelled all over India without causing a blip on the intelligence radar. Headley had made frequent trips to India between 2006 and 2009, carrying out reces of possible terror targets. Rana was given a multiple-entry visa for a whole year; his wife Samraz Rana Akhtar held a five-year multiple-entry visa provided by the Indian consulate in 2008.

Stung by the ease with which they gained access to the country, the home ministry has undertaken a comprehensive exercise to get details of visas issued by Indian embassies, high commissions and consulates in the past five years from countries designated sensitive. These include the US, UK, UAE, Saudi Arabia, China, Pakistan, Nepal, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and Iran. Intelligence agencies have been asked to keep strict tabs on issuing of visas, especially to Pakistani nationals and those of Pakistan origin like Headley and Rana. The rules say Pakistani nationals can't be granted Indian visas from a third country. Their visa request is to be considered only if they are applying in Pakistan and that too after the home ministry has cleared their application. In case a Pakistani national applies for a visa from a third country like the UAE, UK or US, it can be granted only under exceptional cir-

cumstances by the mission head. This is what Chicago consulate's head Ashok Atri is believed to have done.

“The gaps in the visa system have been exposed in many cases, the most notable among them being that of Headley. The need to create a fool-proof system cannot be overstated,” Home Minister P. Chidambaram said. According to sources, Chidambaram was in favour of some kind of accountability of mission officials who have goofed up. He had questioned the wisdom of the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) for not acting against Atri, who had issued multiple entry visas to both Headley and Rana.

The MHA's tough visa norms did not find much favour with the MEA when

then Minister of State for External Affairs Shashi Tharoor tweeting that “26/11 killers had no visas”. According to him, visa restrictions did not protect security. Prior to 26/11, there were intelligence reports about a large number of Pakistani nationals getting visas from Dubai. In 2008, some senior officials of the Dubai consulate, including those representing the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW), were found to be involved in issuing passports to relatives of underworld operative Dawood Ibrahim. The matter was hushed up and the R&AW officials and a consulate employee were quietly transferred out.

As per the reports that the home ministry got from various consulates,



Inside OUT

The home ministry pushes for a stricter visa regime to prevent a repeat of the Headley safari and 26/11